

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

QA Strategy Template

A one-page-able quality strategy skeleton — objectives, risks, where effort goes and does not go, environments, data, gates, release approach and explicit non-goals.

Purpose

A QA strategy states how quality will be achieved for a product or organisation, tied to business objectives and risk. This template deliberately keeps it to something that could fit on a page: a strategy nobody reads changes nothing. Its most important and most neglected sections are where effort deliberately does NOT go and the explicit non-goals — because a strategy that claims to do everything is really a strategy for nothing, and it is the things you choose not to do that make the plan credible.

When to use it

- After a current-state assessment, to set direction for the next 6–12 months.
- When aligning multiple squads on a shared approach to quality.
- When you need executive sign-off on where quality investment will and will not go.
- At the start of a significant new product or programme, to set the quality approach up front.

Instructions

Work top to bottom. Anchor everything to the business objectives and the top risks — every choice further down should trace back to one of them. For test levels, state not just what you will do but where effort concentrates and where it deliberately does not. Be specific about environments, test data and quality gates, because these are where good intentions usually fail. Fill in the non-goals last and honestly; they are what stops the strategy quietly expanding until it is undeliverable. Keep the whole thing tight enough to present in ten minutes.

Worked example

A first-year quality strategy skeleton for Northstar Digital, built to serve its objectives: ship faster without more incidents; make the public API dependable enough to sell against SLAs; control cost.

Section	Northstar example content
Mission	Enable Northstar to release faster and more safely by concentrating quality effort on risk, embedding QA earlier, and making quality signals trustworthy.
Objectives (linked to business goals)	1) Cut the release regression bottleneck without raising escaped defects. 2) Make the public API demonstrably dependable enough to sell against SLAs. 3) Do this within current headcount — reduce risk and cost, not grow the team.
Top risks addressed	Late QA engagement causing late, expensive defects; distrusted automation; unstable environments and test data; loose defect prioritisation; no shared definition of done.
Test levels & where effort goes	Shift-left: strong unit and API testing owned by developers; risk-based exploratory testing (our strength) on customer-facing change; a small, trusted, stable automated suite for critical journeys and the public API contract.
Where effort does NOT go	No broad manual regression of unchanged areas. No expansion of the flaky UI suite. No attempt to automate exploratory testing. No gold-plating of low-traffic internal admin tooling.
Environments	Move critical paths off the unstable shared staging towards on-demand, isolated environments for high-risk testing; keep shared staging for low-risk checks.
Test data	Introduce a managed, repeatable test-data approach for critical flows (accounts, payments) so results are reliable and reproducible.
Quality gates	A shared, lightweight definition of done and a release gate: unit + API checks green, critical-journey automated suite green, no open critical/major defects, residual risk stated.
Release approach	Support each squad's own cadence; gate on risk and evidence, not on a calendar-driven 5-day manual pass. Use the residual-risk statement as the release decision, not a QA sign-off ritual.
Metrics	Shift reporting to escaped defects, change failure rate, and time-to-release for critical paths. Retire test-case-count reporting.
Non-goals (this year)	Not building a security or performance testing capability in-house (assess buy-vs-build next year). Not chasing a target automation percentage. Not achieving level-5 maturity everywhere. Not hiring three more testers.

Blank reusable version

Section	Your content
Mission	
Objectives (linked to business goals)	
Top risks addressed	
Test levels & where effort goes	
Where effort does NOT go	
Environments	
Test data	
Quality gates	
Release approach	

Section	Your content
Metrics	
Non-goals (this period)	

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Writing a strategy that lists every good practice with no priorities — which is a wish list, not a strategy. Leaving the "where effort does NOT go" and non-goals sections blank because they feel negative; they are the most valuable part. Copying a strategy from a previous employer without reconnecting it to this context and these risks. Producing a 40-page document that nobody reads or remembers. And failing to tie any of it to the business objectives, so executives cannot see why they should care.

How to interpret the results

- If every objective traces to a business goal and every activity traces to a risk, the strategy is coherent — you can defend any line of it.
- If the non-goals section is empty or vague, the strategy is not finished. Force the trade-offs; an all-of-the-above plan will fail on delivery.
- If stakeholders push back hard on the non-goals, that is the strategy working — it is surfacing the real trade-off conversation before it becomes a mid-year crisis.
- If the strategy could have been written without reading the current-state assessment, it is generic. Rework it until it is unmistakably about your organisation.
- Revisit quarterly. A strategy is a hypothesis about where quality effort pays back best; check whether the evidence still supports it.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

The line that earns executive trust is the one that says what you will not do. "We will stop the 5-day manual regression of unchanged areas and gate on risk instead" tells a VP you understand trade-offs and cost — far more convincing than a page of aspirations. Lead with your non-goals in the room; they are your proof that this is a strategy and not a wish list.